



Tonga



Tonga is an archipelago of 170 islands in the South Pacific. Only 45 of these islands are inhabited. The king's powers have been challenged: democratic reforms are promised for 2010.



GEOGRAPHY

Easterly islands are generally low and fertile. Those in the west are higher and volcanic in origin.



CLIMATE

Tropical oceanic. Temperatures range between 68°F (20°C) and 86°F (30°C) all year round. Heavy rainfall, especially February–March.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tonga is the last remaining Polynesian monarchy. All land belongs to the crown, but is administered by nobles who allot it to the common people. Respect for traditional values is high, though younger, Westernized Tongans are starting to question some attitudes. The first elected commoner became prime minister in 2006.

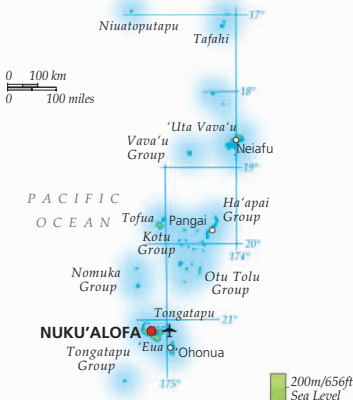


INSIGHT: *Unique in the Pacific, Tonga was never brought under foreign rule*



THE ECONOMY

Squashes and vanilla exported. Remittances. Potential for tourism and fisheries. Capital's business district destroyed in 2006 prodemocracy riots.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Tonga

DATE OF FORMATION: 1970

CAPITAL: Nuku'alofa

POPULATION: 104,000

TOTAL AREA: 289 sq. miles

(748 sq. km)

DENSITY: 374 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Tongan*

RELIGIONS: Free Wesleyan 41%, other 29%, Roman Catholic 16%, Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints 14%

ETHNIC MIX: Tongan 98%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Pa'anga (Tongan dollar)

= 100 seniti